Old traditions die hard

Prior to World War II, American turning could be defined as a process of rotational carving to rapidly produce elements out of an inexpensive and widely available material – wood. The primary use of the lathe as a mass-production tool placed a premium on minimising cost, so that where hand operations were still used, skill was equated with accuracy in speed and production. For the first 75 years of the 20th century, the long historical tradition of woodturning embodied several distinctive attributes (Kelsey, p. 123–124):

- Turning was taught in most secondary schools, along with introductions to general woodworking, metalworking and drafting. It was also taught by master to apprentice, by father to son, and by self-education.
- Turnings were commercial produced in volume, primarily for utility as housewares and structural/decorative elements in furniture and architecture, and in industrial patternmaking en route to cast-iron objects.
- Pattern books were often used as the style source, thus continuing aesthetic traditions even where details were modified or when the worker reinterpreted the specified form.
- Turnings were generally monochromatic, whether of a single wood or as the result of paint.
- Turnings did not tend to result from personal artistic expression.

The times they are a-changin'

Cultural upheaval in the 1960s and 70s created new interest in all traditional crafts. A new wave of woodturning artisans emerged, along with a new market in turning tools, lathes, and materials (Kelsey, p. 19). By the mid-1970s, woodturning had begun to appear in galleries and craft shows, and woodworking magazines covered the techniques and exciting new work of this old craft now recharged with a sense of quality and innovation. Woodturning was taking a uniquely contemporary shape, and the enthusiasm was pushing beyond the isolation of basement and garage workshops. '[American] Woodturners wanted to share their work, their ideas, and their questions' (Mastelli, Mississippi, p. 5).

Numerous woodturning weekend symposiums had been organised, and there had been ground-breaking exhibitions of turned wood. Many late-night conversations had tossed around the idea of an organisation for woodturners, on that could continue to produce symposiums, exhibitions, and events, and become a clearing house for information and ideas (Kelsey, p. 55). Collectively, this extensive growth in such a short period provided the energy, content, and personnel that would help pull woodturning out of the confines of its industrial past and onto a stage in the decorative arts that was shared with the established fields of ceramics, glass, fibre and metal. Unlike these other media fields, woodturning did not have an academic or art(full) base. In effect, woodturning had never graduated beyond a high-school woodshop class, while the other media fields had gone on to graduate school in university art departments (Kelsey, p. 61). The era was ripe for some form of service organisation that could address the collective needs of a growing field that included novice-to-advanced levels of turners, gallery owners, collectors and museum curators (Kelsey, p. 60).

The birth of AAW

PHOTO: MARK LINDQUIST/LINDQUIST STUDIOS

From left: Melvin Lindquist, Rude Osolnik, James Prestini, and Bob Stockdale participate in a panel discussion at the second AAW symposium in Philadelphia, PA in 1988

PHOTO: AMERICAN WOODTURNER

David Ellsworth offers an intimate critique in the 2012 Instant Gallery

Christian Burchard critiqued many of the works in an early Instant Gallery

PHOTO: LARRY MART

Always a centrepiece of the AAW annual symposium, the 1998 Instant Gallery presented nearly 500 participant works

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